



The playbook. Not what we look like — **why it works**,
who it works on, and how we take it to campus.

THE PLAYBOOK · V1
MARK & LANGUAGE LOCKED
ACCENT #00875A

DESIGN SPEC → BRAND.md
THIS DOC → GO-TO-MARKET

01 The product is course planning. The purchase is relief.

Nobody wakes up wanting a degree-audit parser. What a student actually carries is a low, constant dread: *I think I'm behind, I'm not sure, and everyone else seems to have it figured out.*

That dread has three parts, and each one is a marketing target:

- **Uncertainty** — the rules exist, but they're spread across a 40-page handbook, a bulletin site, and an advisor with a three-week queue.
- **Shame** — asking feels like admitting you should already know. This is why students Google at 2am instead of emailing at 2pm.
- **Comparison** — the belief that everyone else has a plan. They don't. They have the same tabs open.

So we never sell features. We sell the **moment the dread ends**. Every asset we make should be legible as: *you were carrying this, now you're not.*

But relief is the door, not the house. Course panic is what makes a student open ACE the first time. It is not what makes them keep it. The next section is the more important half of the strategy, and the half we are most likely to under-sell.

02 Not an app you open. The layer you live on.

A university is an enormous, badly-indexed institution where every answer lives in a different office, on a different website, in a different vocabulary, behind different hours. Students are handed a login and expected to figure it out.

ACE is the layer between a student and that institution — **one place that knows their college**. Not a course tool. Not a semester ritual. Somewhere you go the way you go to a group chat: any hour, any question, no preamble, no sense that the question is too small.

Episodic (what we must not become)

Opened when something breaks. Twice a term, around registration. Scope: courses. The student's mental model is "that degree-audit thing." Churn is invisible because nobody was ever really using it.

Ecosystem (what we are)

Open because it's Tuesday and the dining hall hours are unclear. Scope: being a student here. The mental model is "ask ACE." Course planning is the hardest thing it does, not the only thing.

This is a strategy decision with teeth, and it costs us something: breadth is harder to be right about than depth. We take it anyway, because the alternative is a utility that gets uninstalled in June.

ask your college anything.

03 The surface area

Courses are the wedge: highest stakes, most structured data, hardest to get anywhere else. Everything around it is the ecosystem — and to a student, they are the same kind of question, asked in the same box.

Academic core • Majors, prereqs, requirements, gen-eds, drop/add, GPA, graduation, transfer credit, substitutions, entrance-to-major. Structured and cited to the page. This is the wedge and our moat.	Calendar & logistics Registration windows, add/drop dates, breaks, finals, tuition deadlines, holds on your account, what to do when you miss one.	Places & services Dining hours, library floors, the gym, health and counselling, IT help, printing, parking appeals, transit, mail and packages.
Money Financial aid, the bursar, scholarships, work-study, refunds, what that charge is, who to email about it.	People & belonging Orgs and clubs, how to join after the fair, intramurals, events, greek life, RAs — the questions behind "I haven't found my people yet."	Beyond Internships, the career centre, research with faculty, study abroad, grad school, and the part where college becomes the thing after college.

Nobody currently sells this. Advisors cover academics. Reddit has breadth with no accountability. University websites have documents, not answers. The gap is **breadth plus a citation**, and it is ours to take.

04 The message ladder

One idea per rung. Never skip a rung to sound smarter. Note that the six-word line was always ecosystem-scoped: **college**, sorted — not *courses*, sorted.

SIX WORDS	college, sorted.
ONE LINE	Ask your college anything.
TWO LINES	Courses, deadlines, dining, housing, orgs, the offices nobody explains. Cited, and awake at 2am.
THE PROOF	749 majors. 9,439 courses. 46 handbook rules, cited to the page.
THE THESIS	College is a maze with the map locked in a filing cabinet. We are the navigation layer for the whole institution — courses are the wedge, not the ceiling.

05 **Who we're for, and when**

The primary Undergrad, any major, mid-degree. Not a freshman with a clean slate — a sophomore or junior who has already made one choice they're unsure about. They are the ones with a question that has a wrong answer.	The second audience, free Parents. They never install anything; they receive a screenshot. Every answer should survive being forwarded to someone paying tuition.	The gatekeeper we don't fight Advising offices. We are not a procurement sale and we do not campaign against advisors. We are the hours they don't work.
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Timing is a channel. Demand for ACE is nocturnal and calendar-spiked: the week registration opens, the week before drop deadlines, the night before an advising appointment, and the 48 hours after grades post. Media plans built on a flat weekly cadence will underperform by a wide margin. Spend where the panic is.

06 The period is a closure cue

The mark ends in a full stop. That is not decoration — it is the entire product promise compressed into one glyph, and it works on a mechanism we can name.

An open question occupies working memory; it keeps surfacing until it's closed. A period is the most universally-learned **closure signal** in written language. Putting one at the end of our name means the brand's resting state is *resolved* — and putting it on the send button means the student performs that closure with their own thumb.

Practical consequence: the period never marks a beginning. It is never on a loading state, never on an empty state, never on an error. It appears when something is **done**. Misuse costs us the mechanism.



Four sessions of one colour in one role is enough to build the association. Two roles is enough to destroy it.

07 Colour: conditioning, not symbolism

Most colour psychology sold to marketers is unfalsifiable — "green means growth, blue means trust." Cross-cultural evidence for innate colour meaning is weak, and we're not building on it.

What is real, and what we're actually using:

- **Learned interface convention.** In software, green already means pass, approved, complete. That convention is decades deep and it happens to be exactly our product's payload. We're borrowing a meaning students already hold — not inventing one.
- **Scarcity creates conditioning.** One hue, one role, one appearance per view. Because emerald *only* ever means resolution, repeated exposure trains the association. This is the mechanism; the hue is almost secondary to the discipline.
- **Saliency is measurable.** #00875A clears 4.21:1 on our paper and 4.24:1 on our ink — the best-balanced of sixteen candidates tested. The dot is a control, not an ornament, so it has to be seen at 16px on a phone in daylight.
- **Negative space matters more than the accent.** Six greys with no hue mean the emerald has nothing to compete with. A colourful interface cannot have a meaningful accent.

Why not red: red is conditioned as error and destruction in every interface a student has ever used. For a product whose job is lowering anxiety, spending our one accent on an alarm signal would work directly against the copy. We tested it, it scored fine on contrast, and we rejected it on psychology.

08 Type: we set the type to make college feel doable

The strongest, best-supported effect in this whole document is **processing fluency**: when something is easier to read, people judge the task it describes as easier to do. Same instructions, harder typeface, and readers estimate the task takes longer and are less willing to start.

For a product whose content is *degree requirements* — the single most intimidating body of text in a student's life — that is not a nicety. It is the feature.

HOW THE UNIVERSITY WRITES IT	HOW WE WRITE IT
PRESCRIBED COURSES: 40-49 CREDITS. STUDENTS MUST COMPLETE CMPSC 465 WITH A MINIMUM GRADE OF C. PREREQUISITE: MATH 230 OR CONCURRENT ENROLLMENT. Uppercase, monospaced, no hierarchy. Reads as: this will be hard, and it may be a trap.	retake MATH 230 in fall — it's the gate for CMPSC 465. two courses, one semester, and you're clear. Lowercase, one idea, the number named, the exit stated. Same facts. Different estimate of effort.

The type system encodes three more decisions, each with a job:

- **Lowercase is a register choice.** Capitals are institutional; lowercase is peer. We are the friend who happens to have read the handbook, not the registrar.
- **Mono over numbers only.** Monospaced digits read as machine output — receipts, not claims. 087/120 is believable in a way "72% complete!" is not. Never set marketing copy in mono; it becomes costume.
- **Text caps at 28px; the wordmark carries scale.** Shouting in type reads as a hard sell. Our confidence comes from the mark being enormous and the sentences being calm.

09 The shame-free grammar

Every line we write is read by someone who is slightly afraid of the answer. Four rules:

- **Lead with the verdict.** "yes." then the reason. Never make them read a paragraph to find out if they're okay.
- **Name the mistake as a route, not a failure.** "failed it? rerouted." The student's error is a fact about the map, not a fact about them.
- **Never take the credit.** "you're fine" — not "we fixed it." Agency stays with the student; we're the map, they're the one walking.
- **No exclamation marks.** Confidence doesn't shout, and enthusiasm reads as sales. The period does the work.
- **Never dead-end.** "I can't help with that" is the sentence that turns an ecosystem back into a tool. If we don't know, we give the office, the hours, the email, and the exact thing to ask. A student should never learn that there is a category of question ACE doesn't take.

your 2am question. answered.

10 The lexicon

WE SAY	WE NEVER SAY	BECAUSE
advisor	chatbot, assistant, bot	"Chatbot" sets the expectation of a toy that will waste your time.
sorted · handled · rerouted	optimize, streamline, unlock	Students don't optimize their degree. They want it handled.
the plan · the route	journey, roadmap, pathway	Corporate metaphors. A route is something you follow tonight.
cited to page 14	AI-powered, powered by AI	The model isn't the value; the citation is. Leading with AI invites doubt about accuracy.
every major	student success platform	Nobody has ever said that phrase out loud to a friend.
you're fine	empower, revolutionize, transform	Words that describe how the company feels about itself.

Test for any headline: could a sophomore text this to their roommate without irony?
If not, rewrite it.

11 The dot

Our strongest owned asset is not the wordmark. It is a single emerald dot.

Print die-cut emerald dots — no name, no URL, nothing. Give them away by the thousand at org fairs. A dot on a laptop lid means nothing to an outsider and everything to someone who uses the app. That is an in-group signal, and in-group signals spread without media spend because wearing one is a small act of identity rather than an advertisement.

Precondition: the dot only works if the app is worth being seen with. This play is downstream of product quality, and it fails loudly if we run it early.

12 Own the hour nobody wants

Every competitor markets between 9 and 5. Our user's moment of need is 1am to 3am, and attention is nearly free then.

- Creative that only makes sense late: "*still answering.*" over a 02:46 timestamp.
- Paid social scheduled against the panic window, not the workday.
- The product's own copy acknowledges the hour. Being awake with someone is a relationship, not a transaction.

13 The course-code engine

We hold 9,439 course records and 749 program structures. Every course code is something a student types into a search bar at midnight: "CMPSC 465 prereqs", "MATH 230 hard".

That is thousands of pages of genuinely useful, structurally-generated content we can publish because we already have the data — prerequisite chains, what it gates, which semester it's offered, what it's worth. This is the cheapest durable acquisition channel available to us, and it compounds while we sleep.

Guardrail: generated pages must be genuinely useful and honestly sourced, or this becomes spam that costs us the credibility the rest of the brand is built on. Every page cites the bulletin.

14 Bottom-up, never top-down

Do	Don't
RAs, orientation leaders, club officers, course-specific group chats, upperclassmen in majors with brutal prereq chains. People with a group chat and a reason to look helpful.	University procurement, "official partnership" announcements, anything that positions us as an institutional product. It's slow, it's expensive, and it converts our peer voice into an administrative one.

15 Own week one

Orientation is the highest-question, lowest-relationship week of a student's life. They have a hundred questions and nobody to ask without feeling stupid — where to print, how the dining plan works, what a hold is, where the gym is.

Those questions are trivially easy for us and enormously valuable: **a student who asks ACE about laundry in week one asks about prereqs in week six.** Breadth is how we earn the academic question, not the reverse. Fight for orientation packets, RA scripts, and first-week signage over anything aimed at registration season.

16 The empty state is a positioning statement

The suggested prompts on an empty input teach the user what the product is for. If they all say "plan my semester," we have built an episodic course tool no matter what the marketing says.

So the empty state always mixes registers — one academic, one logistical, one social, one small. "*what's due friday*" next to "*is the library open now*" next to "*how do I join a club in october*". This is a marketing decision that lives in the product, and it is not negotiable to a growth experiment.

Same logic for the app-store screenshots, the landing hero, and every demo we ever record: never show only course questions.

17 Proof by transcript, not by logo wall

"Trusted by 10,000 students" is placeholder thinking, and gen-Z discounts it automatically. Instead we publish **the hardest real questions ACE has answered** — verbatim, with the handbook page cited.

A screenshot of a student asking "*can I still graduate by spring '27 if I failed MATH 230?*" and getting a four-semester plan with a page citation does more than any testimonial, because it is falsifiable. Anyone can check it.

And the inverse: when ACE gets something wrong, publish that too — what it said, what was right, what changed. For an advising product, being publicly correctable is a stronger trust position than being publicly perfect. It also makes us very hard to attack.

18 **The receipt**

Give students a clean, screenshot-able artifact of their plan — credits, semesters, the route, cited. Not because they need it, but because they will send it to a parent, a group chat, or an advisor.

A shareable artifact turns one user into a distribution channel and reaches the tuition-payer without us buying a single impression. Design it to look right at phone-screenshot size, with the wordmark and the period visible.

19 Things we never say

Advising is a domain where a confident wrong answer costs a student a semester and costs us the company. Marketing carries that risk as much as the product does.

- **Never promise an outcome.** Not "graduate on time, guaranteed." We show the route; the student walks it and the university awards the degree.
- **Never imply endorsement.** We are not affiliated with, endorsed by, or speaking for any university. Not in copy, not in visual borrowing, not by implication.
- **Never say we replace advisors.** Beyond being a bad look, it's false — petitions, substitutions and exceptions are human decisions. We say: the advisor who's awake.
- **Never joke about uploaded documents.** Students hand us degree audits. That is sensitive academic data and it is never a punchline, never a growth-hack prompt, never in a screenshot with a real name.
- **Never manufacture urgency.** Real deadlines are urgent enough. Inventing pressure on an anxious audience is the one thing this brand cannot survive doing.

20 Breadth is an accuracy liability. Price it in.

The ecosystem strategy has one serious failure mode: becoming confidently wrong about forty domains instead of reliably right about one. A student who gets bad dining hours forgives us. A student who gets bad drop-deadline advice does not, and neither does their parent.

- **No domain ships without a source.** Academics are structured and citable. Housing, dining, aid and the rest are not — they need curation, a scrape with a freshness date, or an owner. If we can't say where an answer came from, we route to the office instead of guessing.
- **Confidence must be visibly tiered.** A cited handbook rule and a scraped dining hour cannot look identical in the interface. Same voice, different receipt.
- **Expand one domain per term, announced.** Slow, visible breadth beats a silent everything-machine — it also makes the ecosystem legible to users instead of just true internally.

21 The accuracy posture

Our credibility claim is not "we're smart." It's "**here's where that came from.**"

Page-level citation is a marketing asset, not just an engineering detail — it is the difference between a chatbot and an advisor, and it should appear in the product, in screenshots, and in the pitch.

When we're unsure, we say so and point at the human. Hedging correctly is cheaper than being confidently wrong once.

22 Metrics that mean something

Engagement is the wrong goal. A student who spends less time with us and leaves with a plan is a better outcome than one who chats for an hour. Measure resolution.

01

Resolution rate

Share of sessions that end in a stated plan rather than a dead end. The north-star metric. If this falls, nothing else matters.

02

Return at the next spike

Did they come back at the *next* registration window? Retention measured on the product's real rhythm, not on 30-day windows borrowed from consumer apps.

03

Shares per resolved plan

How often a plan leaves the app as a screenshot. Directly measures play 18 and predicts organic growth better than any survey.

Vanity metrics to refuse in reporting: total messages, session length, DAU without resolution context. They reward the wrong product.

23 Launch sequence

BEFORE	Get the product boringly reliable on one campus. Every play in Part IV amplifies whatever the product actually is. Amplifying an unreliable answer engine on an anxious audience is the fastest way to a reputation we can't fix.
SEED	Fifty upperclassmen in prereq-heavy majors. Not a broad beta. Pick the majors where the maze is worst — engineering, CS, nursing — because that's where the relief is most vivid and the word-of-mouth is loudest.
PROVE	Publish twenty transcripts. Play 17. Real questions, real citations, including one where ACE was corrected. This is the asset the rest of the launch links to.
SPREAD	Dots, week one, and the 2am channel. Orientation first — the breadth questions are the cheap way in — then dots at the org fair and creative in the panic hours.
COMPOUND	Turn on the course-code engine. Play 13. Slow to start, impossible to stop. This is what carries growth once the launch energy is gone.
THEN	Second campus, same order. The playbook is per-campus, not national. Resist the urge to go wide before one campus is genuinely served.

24 The one-sentence test

Before anything ships — an ad, a page, a poster, a push notification — it has to pass one question: **does this make a worried student feel more capable, or does it make us look clever?**

If it's the second one, it doesn't ship. That's the whole brand.



THE PLAYBOOK V1
ONE EMERALD PER VIEW. ALWAYS THE PERIOD.